

What the fairway is worth

Yards closer the rough ball must be before it beats the fairway ball. Moderate rough, whole yards.

APPROACH	TOUR PRO	10 HCP	20 HCP	30 HCP *
100 yds	58	32	27	31 *
125 yds	76	28	25	22 *
150 yds	75	23	17	12 *
175 yds	63	16	12	8 *

* Modeled: extrapolated beyond Stagner/Arcos's published 0-to-20 range. At 100 yards the modeled 30 tier lands above the 20. Wobble like that is why modeled numbers carry stars.

The scramble rule

Play the rough ball when it's closer by more than the table number, scaled for the lie:

LIGHT x 0.5

MODERATE x 1.0

DEEP x 1.7

Example: 20-handicap, 150-yard approach. The rough ball needs to be 8 yards closer in light rough, 17 in moderate, 29 in deep, before you play it.

The 240-yard line

Past 240 yards out, a 20-handicap's rough ball outscored the fairway ball at the same distance. A 15-handicap crosses the same line at 250. Real Arcos scoring data; no modeling involved.

Bring a real scramble read. I'll run it through the model.

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SOURCES: BROADIE 2011 SHOTLINK TABLE 9 (TOUR) - LOU STAGNER / ARCCOS PUBLISHED BREAK-EVEN DATA (AMATEUR)
 USGA/R&A 2021 ROUGH-DIFFICULTY SIMULATION, CROSS-CHECKED VS 2025 GOLF DIGEST FIELD TEST (SEVERITY) - GOLFTEC (DISPERSION)
 MODELED FIGURES STARRED, EVERY TIME THEY APPEAR.

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